

Creating AI Champions

Generative AI for Business Leaders & C-Suite | Change Management & Culture

1. Why Champions Matter More Than Executives for AI Adoption

Executive sponsorship is necessary for AI adoption, but it is not sufficient. Research consistently shows that peer influence outweighs top-down directives when it comes to changing daily work habits. A 2022 McKinsey survey of digital transformation initiatives found that organisations with active peer-champion networks were 3.5 times more likely to achieve sustained adoption than those relying solely on leadership mandates.

The reason is simple: employees trust colleagues who share their daily reality more than they trust executives who operate at a strategic altitude. When a peer in the same department says 'this AI tool saved me two hours yesterday,' it carries more weight than a CEO keynote about digital transformation. Champions bridge the gap between strategy and daily practice — they translate executive vision into 'here is how this actually helps you at 9am on a Tuesday.'

Key Point: One executive can influence hundreds directly through communication. Ten champions can influence thousands through peer networks. The multiplication factor is what makes champion programmes the highest-leverage investment in any AI adoption initiative.

2. The Four Characteristics of Effective AI Champions

Not every enthusiastic employee makes a good champion. The role requires a specific combination of traits that blend technical comfort with social influence. Identifying the right people prevents the common failure of appointing 'the IT person' or the most senior person — neither of whom may have the peer influence the role requires.

Characteristic	What It Looks Like	Why It Matters
Tech-Comfortable	Willingly experiments with new tools; not intimidated by unfamiliar interfaces; comfortable with trial and error	Champions must be confident enough to demo tools, troubleshoot basic issues, and model productive experimentation
Peer-Respected	Colleagues come to them for advice informally; their opinions carry weight in team decisions; they influence without formal authority	AI adoption spreads through trust networks. A champion without peer respect is just another trainer — informative but not influential
Naturally Enthusiastic	Gets excited about possibilities; their energy is contagious; frames challenges as opportunities rather than obstacles	Enthusiasm is the emotional fuel of adoption. Champions need to sustain positive energy through the inevitable frustrations of early-stage implementation
Willing to Invest Time	Sees helping others as an opportunity, not a burden; volunteers for cross-functional tasks; takes ownership	The role requires real time commitment — training, office hours, experimentation — and people who

	beyond their job description	resent the extra work will burn out or become resentful quickly
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Who Your Champions Are NOT

Avoid defaulting to obvious but wrong choices. The most senior person in a department may have authority but not peer influence. The IT support person has technical skills but may not be embedded in the department's daily workflow. The youngest employee may be digitally native but may lack the organisational credibility to influence experienced colleagues. The best champions are often mid-career professionals who combine enough technical comfort to experiment with enough institutional credibility that peers take their recommendations seriously.

3. How to Identify Champions in Your Organisation

You likely already know who your potential champions are — they are the people colleagues go to when they have a computer problem, when they need help with a new software system, or when they want an honest opinion about a proposed change. Two practical identification methods:

The Informal Network Survey

Ask department heads and team leads one question: 'When your team encounters a technology challenge or wants to learn a new tool, who do they go to first?' The names that surface repeatedly are your natural champions. This is far more reliable than self-nomination, which attracts enthusiasts who may lack peer influence.

The Observation Method

During your initial AI awareness sessions or demonstrations, watch for specific behaviours: who asks the most questions? Who approaches you afterward to discuss applications? Who is already explaining what they saw to colleagues during the break? These natural behaviours predict champion effectiveness better than any application form.

Real-World Incident — Microsoft's AI Champion Programme (2023): When Microsoft rolled out Copilot across its own workforce, it identified approximately 300 'Copilot Champions' across the company. Rather than selecting based on seniority or technical role, they identified employees who were already informally helping colleagues with technology. These champions received two weeks of early access and advanced training before the general rollout. Microsoft reported that teams with an active champion achieved 40% higher Copilot adoption in the first month compared to teams without one. The programme demonstrated that peer influence, not mandate, drives adoption velocity.

4. The Four Pillars of Champion Empowerment

Identifying champions is only the beginning. Champions who are identified but not empowered become frustrated and disengage. The empowerment framework has four pillars, and all four must be in place for the programme to succeed.

Pillar 1: Early Access and Advanced Training

Champions need to be power users before anyone else starts. Give them access to AI tools two to four weeks before the general rollout. Provide them with in-depth training — a full day compared to the one or two hours everyone else receives. Cover advanced prompt engineering, edge cases, and troubleshooting. By the time the broader rollout begins, champions should be confident enough to demo, answer questions, and troubleshoot basic issues without escalating.

Pillar 2: Dedicated Time Allocation

This is where most champion programmes fail. Organisations identify champions, give them training, then expect them to do all champion work on top of their existing job responsibilities with no time relief. This is a recipe for burnout and resentment. Explicitly allocate 10–20% of a champion's workload for AI-related activities. Put it in their objectives. Discuss it with their manager. Make it clear that champion work is not unpaid overtime — it is a recognised part of their role.

Pillar 3: Visibility and Recognition

Champions invest significant personal energy. Recognise that investment publicly. Feature champions in all-hands meetings, internal newsletters, and leadership forums. Create a formal 'AI Champion' title or badge that appears on their internal profile. When the CEO mentions AI progress, name specific champions and their contributions. Recognition does three things: it rewards current champions, it signals to the organisation that AI adoption is valued, and it creates aspirational pull — other employees start wanting to be champions too.

Pillar 4: Direct Access to Leadership

Champions are your ground-truth sensors. They see adoption barriers, tool limitations, and employee concerns that never make it into executive dashboards. Give them a direct channel — a monthly meeting with the AI leadership team, a dedicated Slack channel monitored by decision-makers, or a formal escalation path that bypasses normal hierarchy. When champions can escalate issues and see action taken, they feel like genuine partners in transformation rather than unpaid trainers.

5. The Five Core Responsibilities of an AI Champion

Responsibility	What It Involves	Frequency
First-Line Support	Answer colleagues' AI questions before they escalate to IT or leadership; troubleshoot basic issues; demonstrate techniques	Daily / as needed
Office Hours and Learning Sessions	Host regular drop-in sessions (30–60 minutes) where colleagues bring questions, see demos, or get hands-on help	Weekly or bi-weekly
Success Story Broadcasting	When a champion discovers an effective AI use case, share it broadly — in team meetings, internal channels, and champion network meetings	Ongoing
Feedback Relay	Provide honest, unfiltered feedback to leadership on adoption challenges, tool limitations, and employee sentiment	Monthly (formal) + ad hoc
Advanced Experimentation	Pioneer advanced use cases, test new AI capabilities, and push boundaries of what is	10–20% of champion time

	possible within the organisation's approved tools	
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The balance matters. If champions spend all their time on support and none on experimentation, they become help-desk staff. If they spend all their time experimenting and none on support, they become disconnected from their peers' real challenges. The most effective champions maintain a 60/40 split: 60% supporting and teaching colleagues, 40% exploring and innovating.

6. Building a Champion Network — Not Just Individual Champions

Individual champions have limited reach. A champion network — a connected community of practice — has exponential reach. The network creates knowledge circulation, emotional support, and collective problem-solving that no individual champion can replicate.

Network Structure

- **Monthly in-person or virtual meeting:** Champions from all departments gather to share learnings, troubleshoot cross-functional challenges, and coordinate efforts. Duration: 60–90 minutes. Agenda: each champion shares their top win, top challenge, and one request.
- **Dedicated communication channel:** A Slack or Teams channel exclusively for champions. This is where real-time knowledge transfer happens — someone posts a challenge, another champion who solved it yesterday shares the fix. The channel should be monitored by the AI programme team but run by champions.
- **Quarterly showcase:** Champions present their best use cases and adoption metrics to senior leadership. This creates accountability, recognition, and a feedback loop between strategy and practice.

Network Evolution

Your champion network is not static. Expect natural turnover as AI becomes routine and some champions' departments reach saturation. New champions will emerge as more employees develop expertise. The programme should have a clear pathway for onboarding new champions and gracefully transitioning veterans into alumni status. The goal is not permanent roles but continuous peer-to-peer knowledge transfer.

Key Point: The champion network is a self-sustaining adoption engine. Once established, it generates its own momentum through peer influence, shared learning, and collective problem-solving. The initial investment in building the network pays compound returns as each champion amplifies every other champion's reach.

7. Scaling Champion Impact — The Multiplier Mathematics

Understanding the scale economics of champion programmes explains why they are the highest-leverage investment in AI adoption.

Approach	Reach	Influence Quality	Cost
CEO keynote	All employees (one-	Low — one-directional, no	Low (time only)

	time)	peer trust dynamic	
Department training sessions	30–50 per session	Medium — professional but not peer-driven	Moderate (trainer + time)
One AI champion per department	15–30 peers per champion (ongoing)	High — peer trust, daily accessibility, contextual relevance	Low (10–20% time allocation)
Champion network (10 champions)	150–300+ peers (ongoing, compounding)	Very high — multi-department, cross-pollinating, self-sustaining	Moderate (time + coordination)

A network of ten champions, each influencing 20–30 peers, creates a persistent influence field across 200–300 employees — and unlike a training session, the influence is daily, contextual, and two-way. Champions answer questions in the moment, share relevant use cases specific to the colleague's work, and provide emotional encouragement during the frustration phase. No formal training programme can replicate this.

8. Common Champion Programme Failures and How to Avoid Them

Failure Pattern	Root Cause	Prevention
Champions burn out within 3 months	No dedicated time allocated; champion work is unpaid extra work	Formally allocate 10–20% of workload; reduce other responsibilities accordingly
Champions lose credibility with peers	Champions evangelise AI but can't solve practical problems colleagues face	Ensure advanced training covers troubleshooting, not just features
Champions become gatekeepers instead of enablers	Champions accumulate too much knowledge without systems to distribute it	Build shared knowledge bases; rotate champion responsibilities
Programme fizzles after initial enthusiasm	No recognition, no accountability, no measurement of champion impact	Track metrics, recognise publicly, report to leadership quarterly
Wrong people selected as champions	Selection based on seniority or technical skill rather than peer influence	Use informal network survey and observation methods for identification

9. Key Terms Glossary

Term	Definition
AI Champion	An employee who serves as a peer-level advocate, trainer, and first-line support resource for AI adoption within their department or team
Champion Network	A structured community of practice connecting AI champions across departments for knowledge sharing, mutual support, and coordinated adoption efforts

Community of Practice	A group of people who share a concern or passion for something and learn how to do it better through regular interaction — applied here to AI adoption
Peer Influence	The impact that colleagues at similar organisational levels have on each other's attitudes, behaviours, and decisions — typically stronger than hierarchical influence for daily behaviour change
Office Hours	Scheduled, recurring drop-in sessions where a champion is available for questions, demonstrations, and hands-on help with AI tools
Knowledge Circulation	The ongoing flow of practical knowledge, tips, and use cases through a champion network — as opposed to one-time knowledge transfer through formal training
First-Line Support	The champion's role as the first person colleagues approach with AI questions, before escalating to IT or formal support channels
Time Allocation	The formal dedication of a percentage of a champion's workload (typically 10–20%) specifically for AI-related champion activities

10. Quick Revision Checklist

- Champions influence through peer trust, not formal authority — that is why they outperform executive mandates for daily adoption
- The four characteristics to look for: tech-comfortable, peer-respected, naturally enthusiastic, and willing to invest time
- Avoid defaulting to the most senior person, the IT person, or the youngest employee — peer influence is the deciding factor
- Use informal network surveys and observation during demos to identify natural champions
- Empower champions with four pillars: early access, dedicated time, visibility/recognition, and direct access to leadership
- Allocate 10–20% of champion workload formally — unfunded champion work leads to burnout within three months
- Five core responsibilities: first-line support, office hours, success story broadcasting, feedback relay, and advanced experimentation
- Build a network, not just individual champions — monthly meetings, a dedicated channel, and quarterly showcases
- Champion networks are self-sustaining adoption engines with compound returns on the initial investment
- Track champion programme health: watch for burnout, credibility loss, gatekeeping, and selection of wrong people
- Expect natural evolution — some champions scale back as AI becomes routine; new champions emerge; this is healthy
- Ten champions in a network can sustain ongoing influence across 200–300+ employees through daily peer interaction

20 Exam-Based MCQs — Creating AI Champions

Test yourself after reading. These questions are written in real exam style — scenario-heavy, with plausible distractors. Read every explanation, including for questions you answered correctly.

Q1. Scenario: *A global consulting firm appoints its Chief Technology Officer as the AI champion for the entire organisation. Despite the CTO's deep technical expertise and genuine enthusiasm for AI, adoption rates plateau at 30% after three months. Department-level employees report feeling that AI is 'an IT thing, not relevant to our work.'* What is the MOST likely reason this champion strategy failed?

- A) The CTO did not receive adequate AI training
- B) A single executive-level champion cannot provide the peer-level, department-specific influence that drives daily adoption
- C) The organisation should have appointed the CEO instead of the CTO
- D) Three months is insufficient time to measure champion programme effectiveness

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because champion effectiveness depends on peer influence — colleagues who share your daily reality and whose recommendations feel personally relevant. A CTO, regardless of expertise, operates at a strategic altitude that most employees don't relate to. The 'IT thing' perception confirms that employees see AI as the CTO's initiative, not their own. A is irrelevant — the CTO has deep technical expertise. C would have the same problem amplified. D is incorrect — three months is sufficient to see meaningful adoption movement if the champion model is working.

Q2. The four characteristics that define an effective AI champion are:

- A) Technical expertise, management authority, budget control, and strategic vision
- B) Tech-comfortable, peer-respected, naturally enthusiastic, and willing to invest time
- C) Seniority, department leadership, formal training certification, and public speaking ability
- D) Coding ability, project management experience, change management certification, and executive sponsorship

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct. These four traits combine the practical ability to use and demonstrate AI tools (tech-comfortable) with the social influence to drive adoption (peer-respected, enthusiastic) and the commitment to sustain the effort (willing to invest time). A describes executive qualities, not peer-champion qualities. C over-indexes on formal authority, which is not what drives peer adoption. D focuses on technical and certification credentials that are neither necessary nor sufficient for the champion role.

Q3. Scenario: *A manufacturing company identified twelve AI champions across its six plants. After four months, eight of them have significantly reduced their champion activities. Exit interviews reveal they feel overworked — champion duties were added to their existing full workload with no relief on other responsibilities.* Which pillar of champion empowerment did the organisation fail to implement?

- A) Early access and advanced training
- B) Visibility and recognition
- C) Dedicated time allocation — formally assigning 10–20% of workload for champion activities
- D) Direct access to leadership and decision-makers

Answer: C **Explanation:** C is correct because the exit interview data directly identifies the problem: champion duties added with no workload relief. The dedicated time allocation pillar requires formally reducing other responsibilities by 10–20% to create space for champion work. Without this, champion work becomes unpaid overtime that leads to predictable burnout. A may have been done — the issue isn't training. B wouldn't solve the workload problem. D is important but not the cause of the burnout.

Q4. The BEST method for identifying potential AI champions in an organisation is:

- A) Asking employees to self-nominate through an internal application form
- B) Selecting the most technically skilled person in each department
- C) Asking department heads 'who do colleagues go to when they encounter a technology challenge?'
- D) Choosing the employee with the most seniority in each team

Answer: C **Explanation:** C is correct because this question identifies people with existing peer influence — the single most important predictor of champion effectiveness. The names that surface repeatedly are people colleagues already trust and seek out, which means the peer-influence dynamic is already established. A attracts enthusiasts who may lack peer influence. B identifies technical skill, which is only one of four required characteristics. D assumes seniority correlates with peer influence, which is often not the case.

Q5. *Scenario:* A financial services firm's champion network has been running for six months. The monthly meeting has become a complaint session about tool limitations, and champions report feeling like 'unpaid helpdesk staff.' Meanwhile, advanced AI experimentation has dropped to zero across all champions.

What is the MOST likely root cause of this programme degradation?

- A) The AI tools selected are fundamentally inadequate for the organisation's needs
- B) The champions were poorly selected and lack the right characteristics
- C) The balance between support responsibilities and experimentation has tilted too far toward support, causing champions to lose their innovative energy
- D) Six months is the natural lifespan of any champion programme

Answer: C **Explanation:** C is correct because the 'unpaid helpdesk' description and zero experimentation are classic signs of an unbalanced champion workload. The recommended 60/40 split (support/experimentation) has shifted to near 100% support, draining the creative energy that makes champion work rewarding. A may contribute but the symptoms describe a workload/role problem, not a tool problem. B is possible but unlikely for all champions simultaneously — this is a structural issue. D is incorrect — well-managed champion programmes sustain for years.

Q6. A champion network's quarterly showcase serves which THREE purposes?

- A) Revenue justification, budget allocation, and vendor evaluation
- B) Accountability for champion performance, recognition of contributions, and feedback loop between practice and strategy

- C) Technical certification, skills assessment, and performance ranking of champions
- D) Executive entertainment, team building, and annual review preparation

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct. The quarterly showcase creates accountability (champions prepare metrics and use cases), recognition (senior leadership sees and acknowledges their contributions), and a feedback loop (practical ground-truth insights inform strategic decisions). A focuses on financial concerns not addressed by showcases. C turns the showcase into an assessment, which would undermine the collaborative culture. D trivialises the strategic value of the showcase.

Q7. Scenario: A retail company's AI champion in the marketing department, Elena, discovers that using AI for customer segmentation analysis cuts the time from three days to four hours. She mentions it in passing to a colleague but doesn't share it more broadly. Three months later, no one else in marketing uses AI for segmentation. Which core champion responsibility did Elena neglect?

- A) First-line support
- B) Advanced experimentation
- C) Success story broadcasting — actively sharing effective use cases so others can replicate them
- D) Feedback relay to leadership

Answer: C **Explanation:** C is correct because Elena discovered a high-impact use case but failed to broadcast it beyond a casual mention. Success story broadcasting requires active, deliberate sharing — in team meetings, internal channels, and champion network sessions — so that the discovery creates organisational value rather than remaining a personal productivity hack. A is about answering questions, which isn't the issue. B was done — she discovered the use case. D is about escalating concerns, not sharing wins.

Q8. Why are mid-career professionals often the MOST effective AI champions?

- A) They have more free time than junior or senior employees
- B) They combine enough technical comfort to experiment with enough institutional credibility that peers take their recommendations seriously
- C) They are the most likely to be promoted as a result of champion work
- D) They have fewer existing responsibilities and can dedicate more time to the role

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because mid-career professionals sit at the intersection of two critical champion qualities: practical comfort with technology (not intimidated by new tools) and established peer credibility (colleagues trust and respect their judgment). Junior employees may have tech comfort but lack organisational credibility. Senior employees may have credibility but sometimes lack tech comfort or daily peer accessibility. A and D are factually incorrect — mid-career professionals typically have substantial workloads.

Q9. Scenario: A healthcare organisation is designing its AI champion programme and has identified 15 potential champions across its hospitals. The programme director is debating between two models: Model A gives each champion full autonomy to run their programme however they see fit, while Model B

creates a structured network with monthly meetings, a shared communication channel, and a quarterly showcase. Which model is MOST likely to produce sustained, organisation-wide adoption?

- A) Model A, because champion autonomy leads to more creative approaches
- B) Model B, because a connected network creates knowledge circulation, emotional support, and collective problem-solving that individual champions cannot replicate
- C) Neither — champion programmes don't work in healthcare settings
- D) A hybrid where champions start with Model A for three months, then transition to Model B

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because a structured network creates exponential value beyond what individual champions can achieve. Monthly meetings enable cross-departmental learning, the communication channel provides real-time support, and the quarterly showcase creates accountability and recognition. Model A's full autonomy risks isolation, inconsistency, and champions feeling unsupported. C is incorrect — champion programmes work across industries. D adds unnecessary complexity and delays the network benefits.

Q10. The dedicated communication channel (e.g., Slack or Teams) for a champion network is MOST valuable because it:

- A) Allows leadership to monitor champion activities and compliance
- B) Creates real-time knowledge transfer — when one champion posts a challenge, another who solved it yesterday shares the fix
- C) Provides a formal record of all AI-related activities for compliance purposes
- D) Replaces the need for monthly in-person champion meetings

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because the channel's primary value is speed-of-knowledge-transfer. Problems that one champion encounters on Monday morning can be solved by another champion's experience by Monday afternoon. This creates a collective intelligence that no individual champion or formal training programme can match. A turns the channel into a surveillance tool, which would suppress honest communication. C mischaracterises its purpose. D is incorrect — the channel supplements, not replaces, structured meetings.

Q11. *Scenario:* *A technology company's AI champion programme has been running for one year. The original 8 champions are now all at advanced AI skill levels and their departments have reached 85% adoption. Three of the champions have expressed interest in stepping back from the role. Meanwhile, five new employees in other departments are showing natural champion behaviours. What should the programme manager do?*

- A) Refuse to let the three veterans step back — they are too valuable to lose
- B) Allow natural transition — onboard the five new champions, transition the three veterans to alumni status, and maintain programme continuity
- C) End the champion programme since adoption is high and it is no longer needed
- D) Replace only the three departing champions with three of the five new candidates

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because champion programme evolution is natural and healthy. Veterans stepping back from departments at 85% adoption makes sense — their work there is largely

done. Transitioning them to alumni status honours their contribution while making space for new champions in departments that still need support. C ignores that new employees, new tools, and new capabilities constantly create adoption needs. D misses the opportunity to expand the programme to departments showing organic interest. A risks burnout and resentment.

Q12. When designing office hours for AI champions, the MOST effective format is:

- A) Monthly two-hour formal presentations on AI capabilities with attendance tracking
- B) Weekly or bi-weekly 30–60 minute drop-in sessions where colleagues bring real questions and get hands-on help
- C) Daily mandatory 15-minute AI standup meetings for the entire department
- D) Quarterly all-day AI workshops with external trainers

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because drop-in office hours create a low-barrier, recurring touchpoint that meets employees where they are. The informal format encourages questions that people might not ask in a formal setting. Weekly or bi-weekly cadence maintains momentum without overwhelming schedules. A is too formal and infrequent. C is excessive and would be counterproductive — daily mandatory meetings create resentment. D is too infrequent to support ongoing adoption.

Q13. *Scenario:* A law firm identifies Marcus, a litigation partner with 20 years of experience, as a potential AI champion. Marcus is enthusiastic about AI and his colleagues deeply respect his judgment. However, the programme manager hesitates because Marcus is 'not a digital native' and needed help setting up his new laptop last month. Should Marcus be selected as an AI champion?

- A) No — his lack of technical proficiency disqualifies him from the champion role
- B) Yes — he meets the key criteria of peer respect, enthusiasm, and willingness to invest time, and his technical comfort with AI tools specifically can be built through advanced training
- C) No — only employees under 40 should be considered for AI champion roles
- D) Yes, but only as a co-champion paired with a younger, more technical employee

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because champion effectiveness depends primarily on peer influence, which Marcus has in abundance. Needing help with laptop setup is not the same as being unable to use AI tools — modern AI has a conversational interface that requires no technical background. His advanced training period will build the specific technical comfort needed. A conflates general IT proficiency with ability to use conversational AI tools. C is age discrimination with no analytical basis. D undervalues Marcus's qualification and creates an unnecessary dependency.

Q14. The feedback relay responsibility of an AI champion is critical because champions:

- A) Have formal authority to make changes to AI tools and policies
- B) See adoption barriers, tool limitations, and employee concerns that never surface in executive dashboards
- C) Are responsible for writing the organisation's AI strategy documents
- D) Must report non-compliant AI usage to the security team

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because champions operate at the ground level where adoption actually happens. They hear the complaints employees don't voice to management, see the workarounds people create when tools don't fit their workflow, and understand the real — not reported — barriers to adoption. This ground-truth intelligence is invaluable for strategy refinement. A is incorrect — champions influence decisions but don't have formal authority over tools. C is a strategic function, not a champion responsibility. D conflates the champion role with a compliance function.

Q15. Scenario: A pharmaceutical company's champion programme tracks three metrics: AI tool login frequency per department, support ticket volume, and the number of new use cases discovered per quarter. In Q2, login frequency increased 25%, support tickets decreased 40%, and new use cases discovered dropped from 15 to 3. What does this pattern MOST likely indicate?

- A) The AI tools are failing and the programme should be paused
- B) Champions are no longer needed since adoption is high
- C) The programme has matured: routine adoption is strong (high logins, low tickets), but champions have shifted too far toward support and stopped experimenting (low new use cases)
- D) The data shows a perfectly healthy programme with no issues

Answer: C **Explanation:** C is correct because the metrics tell a nuanced story. High logins and low support tickets are positive — employees are using AI confidently. But the collapse in new use cases discovered (from 15 to 3) signals that the experimental, innovative dimension of the champion role has stalled. This is the common 60/40 balance problem — champions have become pure support staff. B ignores the experimentation decline. A misreads the data. D ignores the concerning drop in innovation.

Q16. Which of the following is the MOST important reason to create a formal 'AI Champion' title visible on internal profiles?

- A) It adds a line to the champion's CV for future job applications
- B) It signals organisational value placed on AI adoption, rewards current champions, and creates aspirational pull for other employees
- C) It creates legal accountability for the champion's AI-related activities
- D) It allows the IT department to track who has advanced AI access

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because the visible title serves three functions simultaneously: it rewards the champion's investment, it signals to the broader organisation that AI adoption is valued at an institutional level, and it creates aspiration — other employees see the recognition and want to earn it. A is a secondary personal benefit, not the organisational rationale. C mischaracterises the role as a liability position. D is an administrative function unrelated to the recognition purpose.

Q17. Scenario: Two departments in a financial services firm have AI champions. In Department A, the champion has direct access to the AI leadership team and has escalated three tool issues that were fixed within two weeks. In Department B, the champion's escalations go through a four-level approval process

and none have been actioned in three months. Department A's adoption rate is 72%. Department B's is 31%. What does the difference in adoption rates MOST strongly demonstrate?

- A) Department A has more technically skilled employees
- B) The direct access to leadership pillar of champion empowerment has a measurable impact on adoption outcomes because champions who see their feedback acted upon remain engaged and credible
- C) Department B's champion was poorly selected
- D) Financial services departments naturally have different AI adoption rates

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because the controlled comparison isolates the variable: both departments have champions, but only Department A's champion has meaningful access to decision-makers. When a champion escalates issues and sees them fixed, two things happen: the champion stays motivated (their voice matters), and colleagues see that problems get solved (the system is responsive). In Department B, the champion's inability to get issues resolved erodes both the champion's motivation and colleagues' trust in the programme. A, C, and D are unsupported alternative explanations.

Q18. The statement 'one executive can influence hundreds directly, but ten champions can influence thousands through peer networks' illustrates which concept?

- A) Executive authority is less important than headcount in change management
- B) Champions scale influence through peer trust and daily accessibility in ways that executive communication cannot replicate
- C) Organisations should replace executive sponsorship with champion programmes
- D) Champions are more intelligent than executives

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because the multiplication factor comes from two unique properties of peer influence: trust (colleagues believe people who share their daily reality) and daily accessibility (champions are available in the moment, not once a quarter). These properties create a persistent influence field that no executive communication can match. A misreads the point — it's about influence mechanism, not headcount or authority. C is a false dichotomy — both are needed. D is irrelevant and incorrect.

Q19. Scenario: An insurance company's AI champion programme has 12 champions. A survey shows that three champions have become 'gatekeepers' — their departments now route ALL AI questions exclusively through them, and no one else in those departments develops independent AI competence. Other departments where champions encourage self-sufficiency have higher overall AI skill levels. What structural change would MOST effectively address the gatekeeper problem?

- A) Remove the three gatekeeping champions from the programme immediately
- B) Build shared knowledge bases, rotate champion responsibilities, and explicitly redefine the champion role as 'teach to fish' rather than 'fish for others'
- C) Add more champions to those three departments to dilute the gatekeeper effect
- D) Accept gatekeeping as an inevitable and acceptable outcome of champion programmes

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because it addresses the root cause: knowledge concentrated in one

person rather than distributed. Shared knowledge bases make information accessible without the champion as intermediary. Rotating responsibilities prevents any single person from becoming an indispensable bottleneck. Redefining the role toward teaching self-sufficiency resets expectations. A is punitive and loses experienced champions. C may help but doesn't fix the underlying dynamic. D accepts a programme flaw as a feature.

Q20. When selecting AI champions, limiting candidates to young employees based on the assumption they are 'digital natives' is problematic because:

- A) Young employees cost more to train on AI tools
- B) Experienced professionals often extract more value from AI because they have deeper domain knowledge to direct it, and excluding them wastes high-potential champions
- C) Young employees are less reliable in long-term roles
- D) AI tools are specifically designed for experienced professionals

Answer: B **Explanation:** B is correct because AI fluency is not about age — it is about domain knowledge combined with willingness to experiment. A 25-year veteran who understands the nuances of their field can direct AI tools toward higher-value outputs than a junior employee who knows the tool but not the work. Additionally, experienced professionals often have the peer credibility that makes champion influence effective. A is factually incorrect. C is an age-based stereotype. D mischaracterises AI tools, which are designed for all users.